

Off the Shelf



Battlefield 1942

Multiplayer or bust!

Battlefield 1942 is based on conflicts during World War II. The game plays across four theatres of operation, spread across 16 maps. As a soldier, you can equip yourself with one of the five kits that give you different skills and abilities. A Medic, for example, has good healing abilities but a weak machine gun, while an Engineer can repair vehicles and carry explosives. Regardless of the chosen kit, a player can operate any vehicle or gun emplacement, as and when a mission calls for it.

Vehicles found, though appreciably numerous (land, sea and marine units abound), are difficult to master—shooting from within them is best done in first-person mode, whereas effective manoeuvring requires the third-person view. Toggling



SEA-SOURED WARRIOR: One healthy serving of bombs coming up!

between the two soon becomes a necessary reflex. Primarily designed to be a multiplayer game, 1942 nevertheless offers a single-player campaign, an addition meant to familiarise the player with the vast arsenal

of weapons and vehicles. This offering is bogged down by the AI—friendly units will seldom prove useful during missions, whereas opponents have god-like aim and instincts. Combined, this imparts a frustrating layer to this mode of play. Multiplayer tries to make up and low-ping LAN games are indeed cool. The Internet though, plays a spoil sport. But here the bugs in the game prove a major disappointment—sound issues and disappearing units add to the long load times. These problems may be solved over time and the game would play to potential, but as it stands, *Battlefield 1942* is an average single-player game and an above average multiplayer one—and it desperately needs some patching.

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Digital Illusions ■ **Distributor:** Gayatri Impex ■ **Phone:** 022-23870260 ■ **Web site:** www.ea.com/eagames/official/battlefield1942 ■ **Price:** Rs 1,299 ■ **System requirements:** Pentium 500 MHz processor or equivalent, 128 MB RAM, 32 MB T&L AGP/PCI video card
Rating: ★★☆☆☆

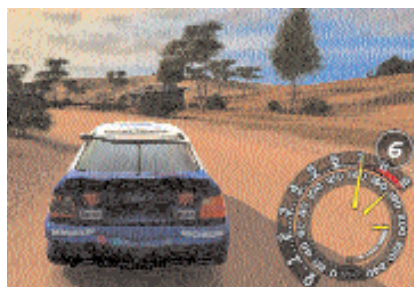


Microsoft RallySport Challenge

Car-dinal fun

With just the right blend of simulation and arcade physics, supported by good graphics and believable damage modelling, *RallySport* serves up a potent cocktail of some fun rallying. The game combines four different types of competitions: Hill Climb, Traditional Rally, RallyCross, and Ice Racing, each with its own set of cars. *RallySport* boasts an impressive stable of 29 licensed cars and several bonus wheelers. The AI is competent and competitive, and poses a healthy challenge as you slide and roll your way through the 48 tracks (safaris in Africa, hill climbs in the US, ice racing on frozen

Nordic roads and more). Cars can be fiddled around for changes in power ratio, suspension, gear ration, steering, etc and the process is friendly enough to comprehend. The graphics are a mixed fare with detailed tracks but the environmental effects could have been more believable. Furthermore, an



DANGEROUS CURVES AHEAD: Good looking, great driving

that should not be missed by any fan of rally racing.

absence of a cockpit view further takes away from an immersive experience that could have been achieved. The soundtrack is very atmospheric—thumping sounds and heavy riffs set the tone for some fast in-the-mud action. *RallySport* is a feature-rich challenge

Genre: Racing ■ **Developer:** Digital Illusions ■ **Distributor:** Microsoft India ■ **Phone:** 011-6294600 ■ **Web site:** www.microsoft.com/games/rallysportchallenge ■ **Price:** Rs 2,649 ■ **System requirements:** Pentium 733 MHz processor or equivalent, 128 MB RAM, 32 MB T&L AGP/PCI video card ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★